

By Carl Pope |

It wasn't the new millennium we expected. History had not ended. Al Gore did not become president of the United States and lead the world in the battle for a clean energy economy and a healed planet. World hunger came roaring back, as did oil shortages and price spikes. The Great Depression paid us a brief, warning visit. Global land grabs, of the kind that dominated the colonial era, reached an unprecedented level, and once again in most cases the beneficiaries were foreigners. Again and again the world found itself dragged to the brink of, or over into, bitter wars over territory that seemed to involve only a fraction of its population, if an awful lot of its liquid hydrocarbons.

The climate models ran, and ran, and ran again. Big chunks of Antarctica plunged spectacularly into the sea, while glaciers in the Himalayas quietly withered away, and Kilimanjaro got browner and browner. Finally the scientists concluded their long debate: not only could human activity disrupt and destroy the stability of the world's climate, it was already measurably doing so. The rest of us tried not to listen. But we need to.

Three facts dominate the new era. Not only are there 6.5 billion people in the world, but most of them now live in soci-

eties that have mastered the trick of economic growth. We will soon have four billion consumers. These new consumers have no great unexplored continents, easily colonisable empires, or unharvested oceans to meet their demands. They are competing with the world's already affluent for limited and shrinking natural resource pie. And the linkage between place and weather, that Bangalore is not like New Delhi, has become contingent—"not yet".

This new world badly needed a movement to address these realities, to organise peoples around a new way of thinking about economic development and the way people relate to place and the future. What filled this need was a nascent global green movement that had been born to clean up after 20th century industrialism and now found itself called upon to envisage a new 21st century post-industrial equilibrium.

How did we do? Not well enough of course. Indeed, one can argue that in many ways the first decade of the millennium was largely wasted. Greens persevered. In some countries, they were threatened, even killed for trying to stand up to predatory industries or corrupt local power structures. China, at one point, had over 20,000 violent protests over pollution or land seizures in a single year. In others, they were marginalised, scoffed at. In the US, we endured almost a decade of a gov-

A BLUFFER'S GUIDE

- Global warming is the constant increase in the average temperature of the earth's atmosphere due to increased emission of carbon dioxide. Nineteen of the world's 20 warmest years have occurred since 1980.
- The Kyoto Protocol, adopted in 1997, is an international initiative to deal with this problem. The US, the largest greenhouse gas producer, refuses to sign it.

THE MELTING OF POLAR ICECAPS POSES A THREAT TO ISLAND NATIONS LIKE THE MALDIVES

SKATING on Thin Ice

A new economic model is needed to replace 20th century industrialism, one that can cope with the billions of new consumers, exhausted ecosystems and an unstable climate

